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From Forms to Form

Author(s): Raphaël Ouellet

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From Forms to Form: Contemporary Art and the Practice of Bureaucratic Everyday Life[1]

/ Raphaël Ouellet /

Raphaël Ouellet (he/they) is a cultural worker, author, and art historian working in Montréal/Tiohtià:ke/Mooniyang and currently studying in the Art History PhD program at Université du Québec à Montréal.
– ouellet.raphael@courrier.uqam.ca

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Cet essai propose une nouvelle manière de considérer la bureaucratie néolibérale au sein du champ de l'art contemporain en mettant l'accent sur la manière dont les abstractions administratives sont vécues concrètement. La bureaucratie se définit comme un processus d'abstraction de la réalité en des normes, des processus et des catégories qui, à l'ère néolibérale, proviennent essentiellement de l'entreprise privée. Puisque ces abstractions deviennent souvent plus importantes que les réalités qu'elles décrivent, je propose une analyse d'œuvres contemporaines qui explorent la réalité du travail d'artistes sous la bureaucratie néolibérale et la violence symbolique qu'elle engendre. Par le biais d'une lecture des œuvres Popularity *(2012) de Joshua Schwebel,* The Gathering *(2020) de John Boyle-Singfield et de l'installation* Le Ministère *(2022) par le collectif CODE BLANC, l'infrastructure administrative de l'art contemporain sera mise en lumière, afin de questionner ses fondements idéologiques et de rendre ses conséquences visibles.*

My aim with this paper is to propose a novel way of thinking about neoliberal bureaucracy within the field of contemporary art by focusing on how administrative abstractions are lived through and experienced. Through these fragments, the gap between bureaucracy's abstractions and the complexities of reality—and the symbolic violence that results—comes into light. Bureaucracy currently exists in every aspect of art production and diffusion; it seeps into every aspect of the field of contemporary art, from the management of museums, art councils, and galleries to grant applications by artists and artist-run centres. Although widely associated with the state and its institutions, it is the main way of governing labor, information, and resources in almost any contemporary organization, public or private. Even as bureaucracy demands constant and tedious work by artist and cultural workers, it remains understudied in our field. While some research has touched on neoliberal bureaucracy in the field of contemporary art—mostly regarding the relation it maintains with artist-run centres, and how it operates within them—it rarely constitutes the main subject of inquiry.[2] However, to try to understand bureaucracy as a unified system with its own logics—informed by values of rationalization, profitability, and efficacy—only obscure it. Its rules seem arbitrary, its criteria contradictory. Its operations appear to favor statistical abstractions and artificial categories instead of concrete reality. In addition, under neoliberalism, as the links between institutions and private enterprise become manifest, artists and art theorists seem ill-equiped by previous analysis to critique bureaucracy and management in their present iteration, a phenomenon sociologist Eve Chiapello calls "a crisis of criticism" within the arts.[3]

This essay, then, suggests new methods for considering bureaucracy in the field of contemporary art. While the work of artists linked to the larger field of institutional critique, such as Hans Haake and Andrea Fraser, offers some insight, this essay will focus on contemporary art practices that specificaly tackle neoliberal administrative structures. Such analysis not only reveals neoliberal bureaucracy as it is lived with and lived through, but also considers what this system silences, deforms and erases and the symbolic violence it inflicts on artists and cultural workers. I will focus my attention on neoliberal bureaucracy within the Québec field of contemporary art, the milieu I work in as a researcher and as a cultural worker. Following a theoretical summary of the relationship between neoliberal bureaucracy and abstraction, I will confront theses systems with their material impact by considering three artworks that explore arts' bureaucracies: Joshua Schwebel's *Popularity* / fig. 1 /, John Boyle-Singfield's *The Gathering* / fig. 2 /, and CODE BLANC's *Le Ministère* / fig. 3 /.

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NEOLIBERAL BUREAUCRACY AS ABSTRACTION

Political scientist Béatrice Hibou refers to neoliberal bureaucracy as "the diffusion of bureaucratic practices from the market and private enterprise: it is not an institution, an administration, or a hierarchical apparatus specific to the State, but an ensemble of norms, rules, proceedings, and formalities that encompass not only the States' administration, but society as a whole."[4] Such norms, rules, and proceedings originate from real situations and derive from actions performed at a precise moment to solve a precise problem. These actions are then abstracted as rules and extended to similar situations. Specific to neoliberal bureaucracy is the process of formalization whereby these abstractions, which generally originate in private enterprise, are pushed to extremes. The abstractions—the values of entrepreneurship, such as competition, individualism, and bottom-line thinking—form the entirety of the ways organizations are governed. This process of neoliberal bureaucratization can be defined, according to Hibou, as

> an elaboration, a work of abstraction that aims to fit complex realities into categories, norms, and general and formal rules coming from a system of thought that rationalizes society and the government of goods, people, and territories from the perspective of the market and the enterprise.[5]

These abstractions are nothing more than arbitrary indicators chosen as efficient representations of reality. The principal problem with neoliberal and bureaucratic processes of abstraction is that norms, rules, and proceedings are not understood as arbitrary, but rather conceived as rational, neutral, and self-evident representations of reality. The abstraction, for bureaucracy, becomes reality. This normalization, an act of symbolic violence, excludes and rejects anything that does not fit in this abstracted version of reality.[6]

According to radical anthropologist and activist David Graeber, such an abstracted perception of reality is the formalization of what he calls "inegalitarian structures of imagination." Graeber, taking inspiration from Black and feminist thought, bell hooks's in particular,[7] argues that, in a relationship defined by an inequal status between two parts, the dominant entity will have to know nothing of the dominated and won't ever imagine what it is like to be the other. Conversely, the dominated will have to know as much as possible about the dominant and to imagine its viewpoint to avoid violence. Bureaucratic abstractions thus formalize unequal balances of power as they create abstracted and schematic knowledge of the world.[8] A consequence of this worldview is the avoidance of interpretative work, which is seen as peripheral to the organization in the execution of its aims. The result is a form of symbolic violence where real people and real situations are reduced to statistics, ticked boxes, and arbitrary abstractions.

These abstracted norms, rules, and processes cannot be understood without considering how they are used in practice. They are what one could name *formalities*. For instance, a rule can be put into place and applied in a way that is contrary to its original intent. A norm or criteria can be adopted

1 Initially presented during the UAAC conference panel "Sizing up the Local: Situating the Subject of Micro-Art History," chaired by Prof. Martha Langford, October 21, 2023.

2 Some of this research includes: Vincent Bonin, *Protocoles documentaires (1967–1975) / Documentary Protocols (1967–1975)* (Montreal: Leonard and Bina Ellen Gallery, 2010); Clive Robertson, *Policy Matters: Administrations of Art and Culture* (YYZ Books, 2006); Laurence D. Dubuc, "L'Action stratégique des artistes en arts visuels et de leurs collectifs en contexte de précarité du travail: Quel(s) rôles pour les centres d'artistes autogérés à Montréal?" (PhD diss., Université de Montréal, École de relations industrielles, 2022).

3 Ève Chiapello, *Artistes versus managers. Le management culturel face à la critique artiste* (Paris: Métailié, 1998).

4 Béatrice Hibou, *La bureaucratisation du monde à l'ère néolibérale* (Paris: La découverte, 2012), 16. All translations by the author.

5 Hibou, 37.

6 Hibou, 43, 113–14.

7 bell hooks, "Representations of Whiteness," *Black Looks: Race and Reprensentation* (Boston: South End Press, 1992), quoted in David Graeber, *The Utopia of Rules: On Technology, Stupidity, and the Secret Joys of Bureaucracy* (New York: Melville House, 2015), 70–71.

8 Graeber, 70–71, 81.

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for appearance without the intention to apply it. Two or more rules can be contradictory, and a choice about which to use must be made. In fact, such play around the rules is necessary for bureaucracy to function. These are the ways abstractions are put into practice. A *formality* is then both the abstraction and the way it is concretely applied. *Informalities*, on the other hand, concern everything that is necessary for bureaucracy to function but cannot be formalized or escape normalization. If the abstract nature of rules and norms prevents them from being applied integrally, it also often inhibits them from being applied at all. The bureaucratic organization, or its workers, then craft a solution or an arrangement. Informalities also inhabit phenomena that cannot be abstracted by bureaucracy, but that bureaucracy nonetheless must manage,[9] such as personal relationships between administrators, the need for care work between workers, and, I would argue, the symbolic and aesthetic processes needed to create art.

Forming the bridge between abstraction and reality, formalities and informalities are essential to the functioning of bureaucracy. Neither strictly beneficial nor detrimental, they give bureaucrats and members of the public some leeway or freedom to divert and deflect the rules and norms they are bound to. On the other hand, they can also grant arbitrary power to some individuals and open the way for organizations to escape accountability.[10] For Hibou, paraphrasing Michel de Certeau, it is through these processes that the "bureaucracy of everyday life" is created. The real sense of neoliberal bureaucracy does not come from its abstractions, but from how the formal and informal rules are used, transformed, and manipulated in daily practice.[11] Therefore, as Hibou shows, it is essential to adopt a viewpoint on neoliberal bureaucracy *from the bottom*: a perspective that sees bureaucratic abstraction as it is applied and used. The phenomenon, then, cannot be completely understood through its formal rules, criteria, categories, or norms, but through anecdotes, lived experience and testimonies.

To understand the role neoliberal bureaucracy plays in the field of contemporary art and to shed light on the symbolic violence it deploys, it becomes necessary to consider how it materially affects artistic practices, working conditions, and artworks. The following works by Joshua Schwebel, John Boyle-Singfield and the CODE BLANC collective all reflect on encounters with bureaucracy. These personal perspectives counter bureaucratic epistemologies by putting the abstractions back in contact with their actual impact, allowing us to grasp how abstractions grow and transform into something that is applied to reality.

AGAINST THE STATISTIC: JOSHUA SCHWEBEL'S *POPULARITY* (2012)

Joshua Schwebel is a conceptual artist working between Montreal and Berlin. In his 2012 performance work *Popularity* / fig. 1 /, funded by the Conseil des arts et des lettres du Québec (CALQ), Schwebel paid thirty-five people to visit an exhibition in an artist-run centre in Montreal every day during its run, for a minimum of ten minutes every time. The paid performers were asked to act as naturally as possible and to engage with the show as any other visitor would. As neither the artists nor the centre was informed of the performance, more than 750 falsified visits were created over the course of the exhibition. As the performative artwork went on, the gallery's employees registered attendance statistics and submited them to CADAC (Canadian Arts Data/Données sur les arts au Canada), a website dedicated to retrieving and distributing data on Arts organizations in Canada. As part of

9 Hibou, 163–66, 172.
10 Hibou, 177–82.
11 Hibou, 143, 157.

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Over the course of a single, five-week exhibition. I paid people to attend a gallery as counterfeit spectators. I did so to artificially inflate the popularity of the show.

The action was executed without the knowledge or consent of the staff of the artist's-run centre, or the artist whose show was inexplicably popular.

My 'art public' of 35 people per day attended a single show every day for five weeks, standing in the gallery for a minimum of ten minutes. In total almost 1,000 counterfeit visits were generated.

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/ fig. 1 / Joshua Schwebel, *Popularity (postcard)*, 2012. 4 × 5½ in. Courtesy of the artist. (previous page)

the assessment of their general functioning, these organizations must submit an attendance report every year to receive funding from the Canada Council for the Arts. The impact of organizations' activities is then reduced to a single aspect, namely the number of visitors to their exhibitions. In an interview for the *Canadian Theatre Review* in 2015, Schwebel states that the artwork stemmed from a concern that the Council's assessment measures ignored any other way to engage with the work. Through this statistic, it is impossible to consider the quality, the many interpretations, or the experience of works of art. What matters is only *popularity*, itself narrowly defined.[12]

As these falsified statistics were submitted into the system in good faith by cultural workers, unknowingly participating in Schwebel's artwork, the self-evident, neutral, and rational nature of the bureaucratic abstraction was put into question. The constructed and arbitrary quality of the statistic becomes manifest, as does its inability to correctly represent the activities of the gallery. After the performance, Schwebel sent a postcard to artist-run centres across Canada, which described his number-falsifying artwork without mentioning the gallery, the city in which the performance took place, and the precise dates of the event. The results are that attendance statistics of all art shows organized by artist-run centres in 2012 became suspect and any funding based on the popularity of an exhibition was thus possibly rooted in fabricated statistics.[13]

This project was submitted for funding both to the Conseil des arts et des lettres du Québec and to the Canada Council for the Arts, which was conducting the survey critiqued by the performance. As the latter refused to fund the work, Québec's council funded it in full. *Popularity* then signifies one bureaucracy disrupting the activities of another. Schwebel also mentioned in the *Canadian Theatre Review* interview that he documented the work by way of receipts, which recorded how the artist paid the performers. This documentation proved inadequate for the Québec funding body as it requires visual documentation for performance art. Because Schwebel never photographed the artwork as it took place—he never set foot in the gallery—he was unable to fulfil the bureaucratic requirement. Therefore, he went to an unrelated event in the same gallery and took three photographs, which he later submitted to the Council (and which were accepted) as proof of his completed work. The real visitors of the gallery then became the fake performers, and the fake performers remained the real, abstracted, statistical visitors of an unknown art show.[14]

Did the Québec Art council employees approving these images know they were fake? Did they even care? Did they, as formalities, just tick a box, file their report, and move on? *Popularity* informally affects the workings of art's bureaucracy, but it is also affected by the informalities of bureaucracy. It is as much a grain of sand in its gears as it is a by-product of this very machine. Both *Popularity*'s status as an artwork *on* bureaucracy and a product *of* bureaucracy disrupts the bureaucratic production of knowledge and its pretention to a real understanding of the world.

THE BUREAUCRATIC ALTER-EGO: JOHN BOYLE SINGFIELD'S *THE GATHERING*

John Boyle-Singfield's video installation, *The Gathering* / fig. 2 /, was presented in 2020 in AXENÉO7 in Gatineau, Québec. The piece includes a short film,

12 Joshua Schwebel, "Popularity: The Spectator as Statistic," *Canadian Theatre Review* 162 (Spring 2015): 31–33.

13 Schwebel, 31–33.

14 Schwebel, 31–33.

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/ fig. 2 / John Boyle-Singfield, *The Gathering*, 2020. Video installation, 5 mins. Documentation by Jonathan Lorange. Exhibition view at AXENÉO7, Gatineau.

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/ fig. 3 / John Boyle-Singfield, *The Gathering*, 2020. Video installation, 5 mins. Documentation by Jonathan Lorange. Exhibition view at AXENÉO7, Gatineau.

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projected on the wall of the gallery. The first sequences show the offices of the Canada Council for the Arts in Ottawa. A vacant welcome desk leads through the empty chairs of waiting rooms, through the glass walls and wood furniture between which the fate of artists all over Canada are decided. The films then takes us outside the building, making its way to a nearby role-playing game (RPG) and fantasy shop. Next to the projection, a character sheet, used to create a character in such games, is locked in a plastic box.[15]

For Graeber, even our antibureaucratic fantasies are shaped and contaminated by bureaucratic values and processes. These tabletop RPGs inhabit a bloody world, ruled by heroes of legend, woven into narratives of struggle, magic, honor and glory. Yet, the mechanisms of its battles and adventures are determined by statistics, which quantify and measure strength, charisma, intelligence, and power. These characteristics, unmeasurable in our world, correspond to the bureaucratic imaginary of total normalization.[16]

The link between these fantastical universes and the Canada Council then becomes manifest: art, as an apparently unbureaucratic activity, needs to be abstracted into a language that will be understood by bureaucracy. This demand for abstraction extends to artists and their funding processes. Bureaucracy, in its desire for transparency and neutrality, but also in its unwillingness to go beyond its own abstractions, needs forms composed of statistics, numbers, or simple texts that can be easily understood without interpretative effort.[17] This type of language, however, is far from the self-evident and neutral representation it presents itself as. By completing Arts Council forms, artists abstracts themselves in order to comply with the bureaucratic process, just as one would abstract the characteristics of a character in a RPG. Just as a fantastical character can be described by its luck, charisma, or strength statistics, artists are reduced to their diplomas, the number of shows they have done, the grants they received in the past, etc. In organizations such as the Canada Council for the Arts, juries awarding the grants are composed of other artists who are familiar with the abstracted and arbitrary nature of the forms, but these forms are the only depiction admissible of the artist and their project. As bureaucratic abstractions present themselves as neutral, rational, and transparent, and as nothing outside the lines of the document may be considered, the form becomes more than a representation of the artist or the project. In the eyes of bureaucracy, it might as well be the artist, it might as well be the project.

The current neoliberal regime exacerbates this demand for abstraction. As Michel Foucault puts it, neoliberalism ensures that market logics permeate all social life. It forces us to become "entrepreneurs of ourselves" with the result that we show and develop our "human capital," namely our capacities, our knowledge, and our experiences, as selling points for ourselves as workers.[18] In a grant application to an art council, this human capital is measured according to the resumé, the experiences, the education of the artist, their ability to explain the project using non-symbolic language, their administrative capabilities to handle a budget and manage a project. The forms and its abstractions then become a bureaucratic performance of the neoliberal self and of its human capital.

Boyle-Singfield's artwork then becomes a way to reflect on the bureaucratic abstraction of the self and of art. Just like the character sheet, the grant application form serves to quantify the unquantifiable into a performative portrait of the artist. Boyle-Singfield's work asks the questions: how

15 "John Boyle-Singfield: The Gathering," AXENÉO7, 2020, https://axeneo7.com/en/archives/the-gathering.
16 Graeber, 189.
17 Graeber, 66–67.
18 Michel Foucault, *Naissance de la biopolitique. Cours au Collège de France 1978-1979* (Paris: Seuil, 2004), 232–33. Translation author's own.

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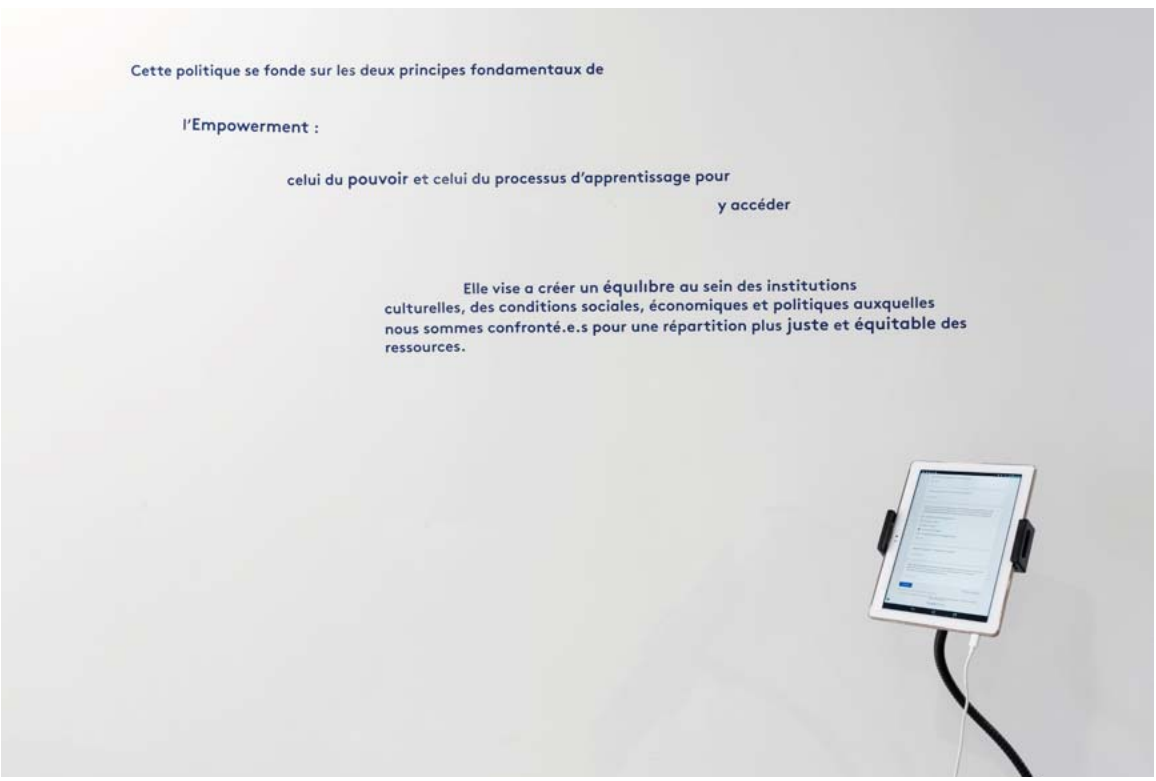

/ fig. 4 / CODE BLANC (Maryam Izadifard, My-Van Dam, eand Stanley Février), *Le Ministère*, 2022. Performative installation, documentation photographs by Guy L'Heureux. Courtesy of articule, Montreal.

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much of this bureaucratic performance is in good faith, and how much of it directly responds to rules and norms? How much of it is written as a formality, just to qualify? Do the artists in the juries know that parts of the art project described in the form were never going to be realized? Can they see through the performance? The grant application form does not propose a neutral representation of the work or the artist. It instead constructs human capital, a reduced abstraction of the real created to convince the funding body of the value of the artist, whose sincerity cannot be evaluated.

BUREAUCRACY AS A SITE OF STRUGGLE: CODE BLANC'S *LE MINISTÈRE*

CODE BLANC is an artist collective composed of Montreal-based artists Maryam Izadifard, My Van Dam, and Stanley Février. Their performative installation *Le Ministère* / fig. 3 / was presented in Montreal artist-run centre articule in the fall of 2022. The piece transformed the space of the gallery into a government office, complete with a waiting room, desks, informative pamphlets, and official portraits of "ministers." Posters on the walls ask: "Decisions: by whom for whom?"; "Where is the discussion?"; "Affirmative action: for how long?"; "We have our quota, thank you, see you next year!". The artists also organized *consultations*, performances aimed at discussing inclusivity in Québec's art institutions and artworld, and a survey on the subject was also available to fill in during the show's run. The final element of the work is a website, which explains the role and policies of this new Ministry, especially the Policy for Empowerment, Equity, Equality, and Justice (or PEEEJ).[19]

Le Ministère proposes a criticism of current diversity policy within Québec's institutions. Sara Ahmed, in *On Being Included*, highlights issues with policies of this kind, which recoup many characteristics of neoliberal bureaucracy. For instance, diversity policy can be adopted in a strictly formal manner without supporting diversity efforts in concrete terms. This leads to what Ahmed calls a "tick-box approach": the inclusivity policy becomes limited to a few criteria, represented by ticking boxes on a form. For instance, an arbitrary number or percentage of employees representing different indentities within an organization can be used as an alibi for avoiding real systemic change; diversity then becomes nothing more than a public relations strategy. These criteria, as arbitrary abstractions of much more complex issues, then become more important than the reality they represent. This approach also maintains the power imbalance between the institution—unable and unwilling to address racism—and the racialized communities they are supposed to "include." As Ahmed mentions, and as it is argued in the artwork, this form of tokenism often means that the people "to be included" are bound to do most of the inclusion work, sometimes within an unwilling institution.[20]

Le Ministère therefore highlights the gaps between abstract norms and proceedings, on the one hand, and the informal way in which they are applied, on the other. These gaps act to strengthen the power imbalance between a bureaucratic organization and the public. CODE BLANC, then, critiques the bureaucratic space not only as such, but also as a site of power from which, as racialized artists, they are often excluded. Some of the actions suggested by the artwork and enacted by the collective use —and, at the same time, divert—this bureaucratic language. The "consultations" that took place became occasions for members of the artistic community to share their stories. The PEEEJ also specifies the need for the empowerment of marginalized communities within the art world, that is, a radical change in how power

19 The mandates, the roles of each of the ministers, and the policies of the "ministries" are available on the artwork's website: www.code-blanc.com/leministere.

20 Sara Ahmed, *On Being Included: Racism and Diversity in Institutional Life* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2012), 107–105, 113.

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is distributed. Good faith, however, can never be ensured by bureaucratic means, as it can never be normalized and enforced by them. With *Le Ministère*, Izadifard, Février and Dam start from bureaucratic language and end up with what cannot be quantified or measured: a change in cultural representation and in the dynamics of power. These changes then concern not only the abstractions of bureaucracy, but how they are applied and lived through as stories we share.

CONCLUSION

Throughout this essay, I have tried to emphasize the gap between neoliberal bureaucratic abstractions and the complex lived realities they aim to represent and shape. The artworks presented, through their respective examinations of attendance statistics, funding applications, and diversity policy, question bureaucratic epistemologies and the symbolic violence that they engender. These systems of knowledge are not—as neoliberal and bureaucratic ideologies would have us believe—neutral or self-evident representations of reality, but a result of the inegalitarian structures of the imagination within insitutions and the balances of power that enable them.

While I have delved into state institutions within the Canadian and Québécois art ecosystem, neoliberal bureaucracy touches every organization, public or private, in our field: museums, artist-run centres, galleries, and universities. This essay is part of a larger project related to a better understanding of how bureaucracies are lived with and lived through. Interviews with artists and cultural workers, anecdotes, stories, and lived experiences form the necessary basis for an alternative knowledge of bureaucracy that goes beyond its abstractions. The present essay, then, remains only a sketch of this process. The goal of this research is to better understand the structures that frame and that are enabled by our cultural work, as well as the relationships of power within our fields in order to begin to forge a path towards a less precarious, more inclusive, and more egalitarian art world.

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